> concern with Christian conversion. Dubois was one of the first such missionary ethnographers and, as Bentick duly noted, a great authority at a time when the colonial administration knew so little [emphasis added].

Dirks elucidates in great detail how the missionary role in ethnography resulted in the creation of ‘criminal castes’, ‘martial castes’,[24] ‘martial races’ and ‘tribes’, all with a view to harvest more souls for Christ and also to identify groups whose loyalty to the British coloniser could be trusted. The use of ‘Aryan races’ in George MacMunn’s *The Martial Races of India*, published in 1933,[25] too is underscored for its ethnocentrism based on missionary ethnography and white supremacism based on Christian OET. This is evident from MacMunn’s belief that the martial races were ‘largely the product of the original white (Aryan) races’ and that ‘the white invaders in the days of their early supremacy started the caste system, as a protection, it is believed, against the devastating effect on moral and ethics of miscegenation with Dravidian and aboriginal peoples’. Dirks also highlights the pivotal role played by missionaries, such as Robert Caldwell, in fanning ‘virulent anti-Brahmanism’ owing to which ‘he became an extraordinary figure in the history of the Dravidian movement’ in southern Bharat. Given the connections drawn by Dirks whose relevance to raging contemporary debates are self-evident, I would urge readers to read his work before forming their views on the subject of ‘caste’ and to recognise the deep-seated coloniality in contemporary perceptions of caste.

Similarly, on the creation of the ‘tribal’ identity, the works of S.K. Chaube and Susana B.C. Devalle, which shed light on the creation of this colonial categorisation, are a must-read. While Chaube’s work *Hill Politics in Northeast India* is of immense value in understanding the nexus between the creation of the tribal identity with specific reference to the Northeast and the facilitation of conversion of ‘tribes’ to Christianity, Devalle’s work on the invention of the tribal construct as a colonial category provides broader perspective on the same lines as Dirks’ work on caste. Sample this introduction from Devalle’s work[26]:

> Tribe has been the most salient category used in the study of Indian indigenous ethnic formations: the adivasi societies. It is my contention that the tribal construct in India is a colonial category and that it